The Big Woods

By Patrick F. McManus

Crazy Eddie Muldoon and I had hit a dead spot in an otherwise interesting summer, mostly because Eddie's parents had confined him to his own yard for two weeks. This was shortly after Eddie's father, Mr. Muldoon, had fallen into a pit we had dug for the purpose of trapping wild animals, which we intended to tame and then train to do tricks. Eddie had even found an old chair and made a whip out of a stick and a length of clothesline. Those were the main things you needed to train wild animals, a chair and a whip. Eddie planned to charge people to see the animals perform. It was a good idea and probably would have made Eddie and me some money, but then Eddie's father fell in the pit and ruined everything. Mr. Muldoon wasn't hurt one bit, and neither was the skunk, the only wild animal in the trap at the time, not counting Mr. Muldoon. From all the fuss, a person would have thought we had dug the trap just for

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Eddie's father. It was the wild animal trap that got Eddie confined to his yard. After the first week, I was allowed in to play with him, and it was a good thing, too. Eddie was about ready to go yard-crazy.

INTRODUCTION

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"How's it going?" I asked

"Terrible," he said. "The guards are real mean to me, particularly the one that smells like skunk."

"What do they feed you?"

"Just bread and water. But I've set some snares around the yard to see if I can catch something for supper. Look, a wild pig!" He pointed to a Muldoon chicken approaching one of his snares. The chicken stepped into the snare and pecked at some crumbs Eddie had left on the ground, then wandered off without tripping the snare. Eddie was furious. He took great pride in his snares, even though he had never caught anything with one of them. "Stupid chicken!" he yelled.

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About then one of the guards appeared at the door and said lunch was ready. Eddie and I went in. The guard had placed bowls of soup and a platter of ham sandwiches and a pitcher of lemonade on the table. "Usually, it's just bread and water," Eddie explained as we washed our hands. "The guard didn't want the outside would to know how mean they are to me."

"Go tell your father lunch is ready," the guard said to Eddie.

Eddie sniffed the air. "he's coming now,"

And at that moment Mr. Muldoon stepped on the porch and opened the screen door. He looked at me. "Aha, the other wild-animal tamer," he growled.

"Now, Herbert," Mrs. Muldoon said. "Don't get all fussed up again. The boys just let their imaginations run away from them from time to time."

"Only kidding," Mr. Muldoon said. "But it wouldn't hurt if they penned up their imaginations for the rest of the summer. Eddie must get his imagination from your side of the family. I've never imagined anything in my life. Boys have got to learn to live in the real world.

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Take life like it is, and no complaints. You ever hear me complain? Never!"

"That's good, Herbert, because I have a little job for you. I need some dewberries for jam, and I want you to take the boys out in the woods and pick me a couple of gallons."

Mr. Muldoon started to complain.

"Hooray!" Eddie and I shouted in unison. "You mean the Big Woods, Ma?" Eddie cried.

Mr. Muldoon went on complaining.

"Yes, dear, the Big Woods."

Mr. Muldoon complained even more fiercely. It was hard to believe this was his first time, he did it so well.

"Great!" Eddie yelled. "Maybe we'll even get lost out in the Big Woods and have to build snares to survive. Pat and I will go get the berry buckets out of the garage."

As soon as Mr. Muldoon had finished his lunch, Eddie and I raced across the highway toward the Big Woods, with Mr. Muldoon plodding along behind. Mrs.

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Muldoon stood in the doorway and watched our departure. "You keep a close eye on the boys, Herbert," she called after us. "It would be easy for them to wander off and get lost."

Mr. Muldoon chortled evily.

Eddie and I had named the Big Woods ourselves. There were lots of little woods around that we were allowed to play in, but the Big Woods went on forever. They spread out across the valley, over the foothills, and then climbed the mountains. I was a little concerned about getting lost in the Big Woods, because I didn't have that much faith in Eddie's snares as a means of providing sustenance.

Eddie and I raced along a trail overgrown with ferns taller than ourselves. "Hold up, you rascals!" Mr. Muldoon shouted. "I ain't wearing tennis shoes, like you. Even if a bear was chasin' me, all I could do is walk a little faster." Eddie's father actually grinned at us. He seemed to be enjoying the hike through the woods, even in his big old clod-hopper boots. They probably weighed five pounds each.

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Eddie and I enjoyed the hike, too. The woods were cool and moist and full of a thousand shades of green, with thick blankets of moss covering long-dead fallen trees. Shafts of sunlight slanted through the towering firs and pines and cedars, making bright green blotches in the shadowy woods. Out there in the shadows, perhaps even watching us, were deer and elk and cougars and bears and --!

"Bear!" screamed Crazy Eddie. He pointed into the woods. And there it was! Eight feet tall, mean red eyes glaring from its black hairy head, the fanged mouth twisted back in a horrible snarl!

For a brief moment, Mr. Muldoon seemed almost as startled as I. "That's only a black stump, Eddie," he explained crossly. He picked his hat up off the trail and put it back on his head. "What did I tell you about that imagination of yours! Stop letting it run wild!"

I couldn't believe Eddie had actually mistaken the stump for a bear, and told him so. Anyone could see it was just a stupid old black stump.

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The woods became less enjoyable after our encounter with the stump. "It could have been a bear," Eddie said. Both he and I now looked for other signs of bear in the shadows. We dropped back and followed close behind Mr. Muldoon, who from time to time turned his head casually to peer off to the left and then to the right, probably to check for landmarks. The woods had grown darker and were full of rustling and cracking and creaking sounds we hadn't noticed before.

"How come your mom just doesn't make raspberry jam?" I said to Eddie. "Raspberry jam is good."

"I don't know," Eddie said nervously. "I think raspberry jam would be plenty good enough, don't you, Pa?"

"We come to pic dewberries and we are going to pick dewberries," Mr. Muldoon grumbled. "Bears or no bears."

A few minutes later, the woods thinned and faded away tree by tree, and all at once we were in a big bright clearing, larger than the Muldoons' cow pasture. Dewberry vines were everywhere, climbing over ancient

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brush piles and gray stumps, the vines heavy with black juicy fruit.

"Wow!" Crazy Eddie said. "Look at all the dewberries! Did you know this clearing was here, Pa?"

"Of course I knew it was here," Mr. Muldoon said, smiling. "Did you think I was leading you on a wild-goose chase?"

We went to picking dewberries with a frenzy, stopping only occasionally to gobble handfuls of the sweet, juicy fruit. Eddie and I both exchanged the opinion that dewberries made much better jam than raspberry. As we exhausted each trove of berries, we moved deeper into the clearing, or buckets growing ever heavier. Then Eddie and I spotted a pile of stones black with berries. We raced each other to get to it first. The pile of stones turned out to be the remains of a fireplace. Hidden beneath the grass was the stone foundation of a cabin.

Some distance off were the remains of another fireplace. And beyond that another. And sill another. Gray, weathered boards and cedar shakes were

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scattered about on the ground. Near one of the cabin sites was a patch of wild roses and a gnarled fruit tree.

"Hey, Pa," Eddie called out. "Somebody used to live here. This was once a little town."

Mr. Muldoon straightened up from a tangle of berry vines and rubbed his back. "Yeah," he said. "A long time ago. You guys got your buckets full yet?"

"Just about," Eddie said.

The sun slid down behind the great dark mass of the Big Woods. A cool breeze stirred the tall dry grass of the clearing.

Mr. Muldoon walked over to look at the fireplace.

"What do you suppose happened to the people who lived here?" Eddie asked him.

"Oh, they probably moved away," Mr. Muldoon said.

"Why would they do that?" Eddie said.

"How should I know?" Mr. Muldoon said.

A lone raven flew over, silent except for the rustle of its wings.

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"Maybe they were all murdered," Eddie said. "Some bandits came along and murdered them."

They weren't murdered," Mr. Muldoon said. "They moved away."

A board clattered to the ground on the far side of the clearing. We stared in the direction of the sound. Nothing there. We stared in the direction of the sound. Nothing there. The breeze sighed through the tall grass, as though whispering to us of some dreadful mystery of long ago.

"The murdered people are probably buried under those roses," Eddie said. I looked at the patch of wild roses. It seemed likely. Otherwise, what would wild roses be doing out in the middle of a clearing?

"There are probably ghosts here, don't you think, Pa?" Eddie said. "The ghosts of the poor murdered people."

"Eddie," Mr. Muldoon said. "There's no such thing as ghosts. There you go again, letting your imagination – what's that?"

"What's what, Pa?"

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"Nothing. Just the wind I guess."

"Could have been a ghost," Eddie said. "What did it sound like, Pa?"

Mr. Muldoon didn't reply. He seemed absorbed in thought, possibly reassessing his opinion about the existence of ghosts.

"Gosh," I said. "Maybe I'd better be heading home."

"Me too," Eddie said. It's probably about the time the ghosts come out. I bet they wander around the clearing out here talking to each other after dark, just like they did before they were murdered."

"Eddie . . . " Mr. Muldoon said, stroking the hair on the back of his neck.

A rock tumbled from the fireplace chimney. All three of us jumped. Mr. Muldoon picked his hat up off the ground and slapped it back on his head.

"Yeah," I said. "I'd better head on home." I turned and sauntered toward the entrance of the trail through the Big Woods. I could hear the grass whispering all around me. I sauntered faster. Eddie

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passed me at a quick walk. I started to trot to keep up. Eddie broke into a run. I ran past him. Eddie passed me. I had the distinct feeling something was after us. Now Eddie and I were flying down the trail, running harder and harder, cold sweat streaming out behind. I could hear things gaining on us, an eerie angry rumbling coming closer and closer. We sailed over logs across the trail without even touching them, logs so big Mr. Muldoon had to boost us over them on the way into the dreadful clearing. Eddie slipped and fell, and I leaped over him without even breaking stride and kept going. It was each man for himself now. Eddie shot past me a second later. And at last we burst out of the woods and slid to a stop in the ditch by the highway. The drivers of the cars going by glanced out at us, little realizing they were looking at two boys who had just made a desperate escape from an unknown number of irate ghosts.

"I sure hope the ghosts didn't get Pa," Eddie gasped.

"Me too," I said.

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"Whewee!" Mr. Muldoon said.

Eddie and I whirled around. We thought he'd still be back in the clearing. I couldn't help but stare down at his big old clodhopper boots, to make sure he was still wearing them. He was. They seemed to be giving off steam, but that may have just been my imagination.

Mr. Muldoon sucked in a draft of air, as he glanced back up the trail behind us. "Well, that was invigorating. Gasp! So, you boys thought you could – gasp – race the old man home, did you? Wheweee! I guess I showed you I could – choke- hold my own with a couple of kids even after a late start"

We crossed the highway into Eddie's yard, with Mr. Muldoon stopping to rest every few feet. He seemed a little shaky. "Yep, that was – gasp—quie a race," he said. "I probably would have beaten the two of you, if I hadn't been worried about spilling my bucket of berries. Look here—gasp—I didn't lose a single ber--!

And then Mr. Muldoon slammed facedown on the ground, sending the berries spraying from his bucket.

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"Pa!" Eddie cried out. "Are you all right? What's the matter, Pa? Your heart? Is it your heart?"

Eddie's father rolled over on his back and propped himself up on his elbows. All three of us looked down at his foot. One of Eddie's snares had finally caught something.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Patrick F. McManus
Book: How I Got This Way
ISBN: 978-0805034813
Publisher: Henry Holt & Company
Date (Month/Year): Oct 1995

AWARD HISTORY

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